

The Healing

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The meteorite blocked the sun before it hit the ground. The enormous piece of rock, above. Blackhoof saw the shadow first — a darkness that had no business being there, spreading across the battlefield like a stain. He had just put down his third opponent of the afternoon, and for one suspended moment he simply looked up at the shape falling out of the sky.

Briggs was somewhere in the press ahead. He had dismounted only seconds ago to go for the enemy general directly, the way he sometimes did when the geometry of a fight demanded a smaller instrument, and Blackhoof had held the flank alone and not let himself think about it, because thinking about it didn't help and Briggs had told him so on multiple occasions.

He looked for him now.

There — forty feet ahead, blade out, a goblin general backing away in wrath.

Blackhoof was already moving.

He pulled a second shield from a fallen soldier without breaking stride, felt the weight of it settle into his left hand, and ran. The battlefield parted for him the way battlefields parted for large things moving with intention, and he crossed the distance in seconds and came in low and hit the enemy general with his shoulder and put him on the ground, and then he was over Briggs with both shields up and his body covering the gnome completely and the last thing he did before the dark arrived was press both palms flat against Briggs's chest and push every fragment of warmth he had outward —

Healing hands. Whatever it was worth. Whatever he had left.

"What the hell are you doing—" Briggs started.

Then the world ended. Not in glory, not in fame, but in a bright light, and absolute darkness.

The light came back white.

White canvas above the centaur's eyes, sunlight pressing through, the smell of clean linen and something medicinal that was completely unlike the smell of a goblin field hospital. Somewhere nearby, a woman's voice giving quiet instructions.

He thought, for one disoriented moment, that he had died and went to heaven.

Then his body registered its complete and detailed opinion of recent events, and he revised that assessment.

"Easy," said a voice beside him. Human. Female. "You're safe. Don't try to move yet."

He tried. Everything informed him immediately that this had been a terrible decision.

"I said easy." The voice was not unkind. A face appeared above him — human woman, middle years, the practical expression of someone who spent her days managing people who didn't listen. "You've been out for most of two days. You have broken legs, cracked ribs, and more bruising than I've documented on a single patient before. So. Stay put!"

Blackhoof lay back and looked at the ceiling and breathed.

"Where," he said, "is Sergeant Briggs."

Nobody knew.

That was the thing that kept catching him sideways — not the pain, not the weight of the bandages, not the slow crawl of his own healing magic working through him in the hours between sleep. The human healers moved around him with a careful, considered competence that he was not accustomed to from anything wearing a uniform. They asked him what he needed. They brought him water without being asked. When he dropped the bowl of soup because his hands wouldn't cooperate, the healer who picked it up said "let me hold that for you" and did, without commentary, without the particular expression goblins wore when a centaur needed assistance — the expression that said animal in a language that didn't require words.

He noticed this the way you noticed something only when its absence had been your baseline for long enough.

But underneath it, steady and persistent: where is Briggs. Is he...? Did Blackhoof fail him?

He asked everyone. The healers, the orderlies, the human soldiers who came through with minor wounds and left again. He had one of the nurses send word to the goblin camp. He waited. No one came.

On the third day, when the bones had knitted enough that his legs would bear weight if he was careful and stubborn about it, he got up.

The goblin camp was a twenty-minute walk that took him forty-five, and he arrived in a mood that had been building for three days and had run out of anywhere to go but forward.

The cavalry tents were where they always were, on the eastern edge. He found two of Briggs's soldiers outside them, cleaning equipment with the focused disinterest of men with nothing urgent to do.

"Briggs," he said.

They looked at him — at the bandages, the careful way he was holding himself, the expression on his face.

"He's alive," one of them said quickly. "Came back from the field himself. No injuries. We thought you've stayed under that damn rock they have casted out of the sky!"

The relief arrived and departed in approximately the same second, replaced immediately by something considerably hotter.

No injuries. Alive and uninjured and three days had passed and Briggs had not come.

"Where is he."

"That's — he took leave. Off-camp."

"Where."

The soldier looked uncomfortable. "He didn't say exactly. Gord gave him the leave. He took a pack and went toward the western tree line and that's the last anyone—"

Blackhoof was already moving.

He found Gord, got the same story in more words and less use, and then found the goblin who'd had the western gate watch two nights ago, a young soldier who took one look at Blackhoof's face and decided that horse or not, he is twice his size.

Briggs had left at dusk. He'd had a pack. The pack had been heavy. He'd gone into the western forest and hadn't come back.

Blackhoof stood at the tree line and looked into the dark between the trees and breathed slowly through his nose.

His legs hurt. His ribs hurt. Everything hurt, with the particular persistence of injuries that were healing but hadn't finished yet. The human healers had told him two more days of rest, minimum. He walked into the forest.

He smelled it before he found it — woodsmoke, long since gone cold, and the sweet-sour smell of spirits in quantity. The clearing was small and unremarkable and absolutely devastating. A dead fire. A bedroll that hadn't been slept in so much as collapsed onto.

A small barrel tapped and mostly gone.

And Briggs, on his side in the leaves with one arm under his face, breathing with the slow regularity of someone who had worked very hard to get unconscious and intended to stay that way.

Blackhoof looked at him for a long moment.

Three days. Three days lying in that white tent, asking everyone, sending word, lying awake between healing spells and listening to the camp sounds for a familiar set of footsteps that never came. Three days of the slow, grinding arithmetic of he's not here adding up to something he hadn't let himself name.

He reached down and took Briggs by the shoulder and shook him once, hard.

Nothing.

He shook him again.

Briggs made a sound like a man negotiating with consciousness and losing.

Blackhoof pulled back his hand and hit him across the face with an open palm — not gently. The crack of it was loud in the quiet clearing.

Briggs's eyes opened. Not fully. Halfway, the whites showing more than the iris, the focus of a man looking at the world through several layers of something amber-colored and extremely strong.

"—the hell—" he managed.

"Look at me," centaur shouted. His voice was doing something he hadn't authorized.

Briggs looked. Or tried to. His eyes moved in Blackhoof's general direction and stayed there with the careful effort of someone keeping a boat pointed into a wind.

"...Blacky," he said. The word came out strange. Soft in a way Briggs's words weren't, usually. "Yes."

"You're..." Briggs blinked slowly. Something moved across his face — confusion first, then something that cracked open under it. "You're dead."

Young warrior went still.

"You're dead," Briggs said again, with the flat certainty of a man stating something he had already finished grieving. "I saw it. The rock — you were—" His jaw worked. "Can't be here."

"I'm here," Blackhoof said.

"No." Briggs closed his eyes. "No, you're not. Seen this before. Brain plays games." He moved his arm back over his face.

Briggs didn't hear him. Or maybe he did, but his brain refused to process it. He narrowed his eyes and his lips moved—silently, as if he were speaking to someone else.

"Greyhoof." The name came from deep within, harshly. "Ironhoof." A pause. "And now you. Now you, kid."

Blackhoof held his breath.

Briggs turned on his side, as if someone were sitting there. As if the clearing were full of people only he could see.

"I told him," he muttered, his voice low and weary and so faint that Blackhoof could barely make out the words. "I told him from the start. I won't like you. I've lost too many. Greyhoof knew it. Ironhoof knew it." A long pause. "You didn't know. You were always there. You always walked beside me. You always had that stupid smile." Silence. "I shouldn't have let you go into that battle. I shouldn't have allowed—"

He paused. Something flashed across his face—a grimace or a tremor, hard to tell.

"A great kid," he said, almost in a whisper. "You could have been a great person."

The anger was gone. Just—gone, as if someone had carried it out of the room. In its place was something else, nameless, shapeless, just the weight of what he had understood.

Briggs thought he was dead. So he went into the woods. And he opened a keg. And every time he came to, he opened another bottle, because staying sober with this was something he wasn't going to put up with.

Blackhoof looked at the empty barrel. At the grass, torn from the ground, covered in vomit and worse. At the traces of two days in the leaves.

Briggs mumbled for a moment longer—less coherent now, the words sliding into one another—and then his breathing evened out and deepened, and the silence of the clearing returned.

Centaur waited. Anger definitely forgotten.

He thought I was dead.

He laid down in the leaves beside his sergeant, no - beside his friend. It hurt, but he laid down anyway, and he didn't say anything, because there was nothing to say that would be better than silence, and Briggs had taught him that much at least.

He waited.

It took time.

Briggs surfaced slowly, the way the tide came in — in increments, retreating and returning, each time slightly more present than before. At some point he rolled onto his back. At some point he became aware of the cold. At some point his eyes focused on Blackhoof with something approaching genuine recognition, and he went very still.

"You're actually here," he said.

"I've been here for most of the day."

Briggs looked at him. Then at the clearing. Then, briefly, at the barrel with the expression of a man taking an inventory he wasn't pleased with.

"Right," he said.

He didn't say anything else about it. Blackhoof didn't say anything about the slap — the crack of it still sitting somewhere in the air between them — and Briggs didn't ask about the three days, and neither of them said a word about the soft broken way Briggs had said his name when he'd thought he was talking to a ghost.

Briggs sat up. Sat still for a while. Put his head in his hands.

After a long moment: "There's a stream. East of here."

"I know," Blackhoof said. "I passed it on the way in."

Briggs stood, carefully, with the engineering of a man reconstructing himself from available materials. He retrieved his coat from the leaves, shook it out, put it on. He looked at the clearing once more.

"Don't," centaur whispered.

"I wasn't going to say anything."

"Good."

They stood in the quiet of the trees for a moment, Briggs's stomach made a sound of pointed commentary. Blackhoof's answered it.

They looked at each other.

"Stream," whispered Briggs.

"Then camp,"

"Then food."

"Definitely food."

Briggs turned east, and Blackhoof fell beside him, and they walked through the forest together in the long gold light without speaking, and that was enough, and it was everything, and neither of them needed it to be anything more than what it was.

